that innumerable international and Kashmiri human rights groups have demanded that these illegal torture centres be dismantled, they continue to exist and the officers continue to torture and extort with impunity.

In India, even the human rights groups have not taken up the demand for the dismantling of these mini- Abu Ghraibs. Perhaps it is an unwritten rule of our patriotism that we are silent about torture if it is the torture of Kashmiris.

It was the harassment and threat of the STF camp that brought Afzal to Delhi in the 1990s and he graduated from Delhi University while continuing his business. He already had a son and now he dreamt of living a normal life. He rented a room in Indira Vihar in 2001 and had planned to go home for Id and then bring his wife and son to Delhi.

But even this small dream was cut short when he was arrested from the Srinagar bus stop and framed in the conspiracy to attack the Indian Parliament. He was sentenced to death by all three courts and is now on death row. The special rope for the gallows has been bought from Bihar. The hangman from Meerut found. The date and time for his execution set.[10]

The news was greeted with widespread protests both in Kashmir and in Delhi.

Every television channel organized heated and passionate debates on whether Afzal should hang or should the death sentence be commuted into life imprisonment. Legal luminaries voiced their opinions, politicians made it a political issue and civil rights activists protested.

And then the execution was stayed when his wife Tabassum filed a petition for justice (she did not want to call it a petition for clemency).

The media made it a national issue. But what is the issue? The ultra-nationalists wanted the government to hang Afzal immediately so as to demonstrate to militants and the Kashmiri people that India would not tolerate terrorism. Members of the BJP argued that Afzal must be hanged so as to give justice to the families of security men and women; as an assertion of our national strength in the face of terrorism and as a way of upholding law and order. The BJP was supported by policemen, intelligence agents and those concerned with national security. Although one expert on national security who appeared along with me did say that an assessment of the situation in Kashmir could lead to the decision that Afzal was not hanged as a measure of counter insurgency. In another programme, hosted by Karan Thapar, the show ended with the BJP leader and Congress spokesman giving the same kinds of arguments.